

Chapter 14

The Missing Piece

Roman had been investigating Noah's case quietly for months.

He had followed old records.

Reopened forgotten leads.

Spoken to people who had once been connected to the case.

But every answer seemed to create another question.

That afternoon...

a knock came at his office door.

Roman looked up from the documents in front of him.

"Come in."

His investigator stepped inside.

"Sir."

Roman immediately noticed the seriousness on his face.

"What happened?"

The investigator walked toward the desk and placed a small evidence bag in front of him.

"You should see this."

Roman looked down.

His expression changed.

Inside the bag...

was an old phone.

The screen was badly cracked.

The back was damaged.

Dust had settled around its edges.

Roman slowly picked it up.

His fingers tightened around it.

"Noah's phone..."

The investigator nodded.

"We found it during the search."

Roman stared at the device.

For a moment...

he didn't say anything.

He had spent months looking for answers.

And now...

one of the few things that might still hold them was sitting in his hand.

"Does it work?"

"No."

Roman looked up.

"Can you recover the data?"

The investigator hesitated.

"Maybe."

"Maybe?"

"The damage is severe."

He pointed toward the phone.

"But the storage might still be intact."

Roman's eyes returned to the screen.

"How long?"

"A few days."

Roman was silent.

Then he pushed the phone back toward him.

"Start."

"We'll do everything we can."

Roman stopped him before he could leave.

"And nobody hears about this."

The investigator nodded.

"Understood."

The door closed.

Roman leaned back in his chair.

His eyes remained fixed on the empty doorway.

Noah's phone.

After all this time...

he finally had something real.

But he had no idea what it would reveal.

And somehow...

that frightened him more than having nothing.

Three Days Later...

Elara sat alone in her room.

The lights were off.

Only the city outside illuminated the window.

Her phone lay beside her.

She had been staring at Roman's contact for several minutes.

There were too many things she wanted to ask.

Too many things she wasn't ready to hear.

But one thought kept returning.

Maybe I should listen to him.

She finally picked up her phone.

Typed.

Deleted.

Typed again.

Then finally sent:

Elara:

Can we meet somewhere private?

Roman was sitting in his apartment when the message appeared.

He looked at the screen.

For a moment...

the smallest smile appeared on his face.

Not because he was happy.

Because he knew what this meant.

She had chosen to listen.

He replied:

Roman:

You decided to listen?

Elara stared at his message.

She typed:

Elara:

I'm trying to.

A few seconds passed.

Then Roman sent his address.

Roman:

Come here.

Elara looked at the screen.

Then another message appeared.

Roman:

I'll tell you everything I can.

She read it twice.

Something about the calmness of his words made her nervous.

She locked her phone.

Later that evening...

Elara arrived at Roman's apartment.

The building was quiet.

She stepped out of the elevator.

Before she could knock...

the door opened.

Roman stood there.

He was dressed simply in a dark shirt with the sleeves slightly rolled up.

No suit.

No business expression.

No boardroom distance.

Just Roman.

Calm.

Composed.

There was something different about seeing him away from the office.

He stepped aside.

"You came."

Elara gave him a look.

"I said I would."

"I know."

He closed the door after she entered.

"Sit."

Elara walked into the living room.

The apartment was modern but understated.

Everything was neat.

Nothing looked unnecessary.

Roman walked toward the kitchen.

"Coffee?"

Elara looked at him.

"No."

He nodded.

"Good."

She raised an eyebrow.

"Good?"

"You'd probably accuse me of trying to distract you."

A tiny smile almost appeared on her face.

"Maybe I would."

Roman looked at her for a second.

"Then I'll save us both the argument."

He sat across from her.

The small moment of lightness disappeared.

Silence returned.

Elara finally spoke.

"I want to hear your side."

Roman nodded.

"Then listen carefully."

His voice was calm.

"I don't want you to believe me just because I'm telling you something."

Elara watched him.

"I want you to question everything."

That sentence caught her attention.

Roman continued.

"That night, I didn't come back to the library because of Noah."

Elara frowned.

"Then why?"

"I had left my phone there."

She remained silent.

"By the time I realized it, you had already gone."

"Daniel and Eva were gone too."

Roman's eyes lowered briefly.

"Noah was still inside."

Elara's fingers tightened.

"And then?"

"I went back."

His voice became quieter.

"I entered the building."

"I found the room."

"And I saw Noah."

Elara swallowed.

"She was on the floor."

Roman paused.

"I didn't understand what had happened."

"I started walking toward her."

He stopped.

His jaw tightened slightly.

"Then someone came from behind."

"I felt something hit me."

"And everything went dark."

Elara stared at him.

"When you woke up?"

"A warehouse."

"Did you see who took you?"

"No."

"Nothing?"

"Nothing I can trust."

Elara looked away.

Roman continued.

"I escaped."

"And when I came back..."

His expression hardened.

"The story had already been written."

Elara looked at him.

"You were blamed."

"Yes."

"And everyone believed it."

"Almost everyone."

The way he said it made her pause.

"Almost?"

Roman looked directly at her.

"I never believed it."

Elara's voice softened.

"But I did."

"I know."

"I hated you."

"I know that too."

There was no anger in his reply.

That somehow made it harder to hear.

Elara looked down.

"Why didn't you fight harder?"

Roman was quiet for a moment.

"Because I was fighting to survive first."

She looked up.

"And then?"

"Then I started looking for the truth."

A pause.

"That's what I've been doing ever since."

Elara's eyes narrowed slightly.

"Alone?"

"Mostly."

"Why?"

Roman leaned back.

"Because I didn't know who I could trust."

The room fell silent.

Then Elara asked,

"Did you find anything?"

Roman looked toward the table.

"Maybe."

Her eyes followed his.

He didn't explain.

Not yet.

Elara noticed the hesitation.

"What aren't you telling me?"

Roman looked back at her.

"Something that may change what you believe."

Elara's heartbeat quickened.

"What?"

Roman remained silent for a moment.

Then finally...

"Noah's phone."

Elara froze.

"What?"

Roman's expression remained serious.

"My investigator found it."

He paused.

"It's badly damaged."

"Does it work?"

"No."

"Then how can it help?"

"We're trying to recover the data."

Elara stared at him.

"How long?"

"A few days."

"And if you recover it?"

Roman's eyes stayed on hers.

"Then we might finally have something."

"Something that proves what happened?"

"Maybe."

He leaned forward slightly.

"But there's something you need to understand."

Elara waited.

"Whatever is on that phone..."

Roman's voice became quieter.

"it could change more than just the story about Noah."

Elara's expression tightened.

"What do you mean?"

Roman didn't answer.

Instead, he looked toward the city outside.

For the first time...

his confidence seemed to disappear.

Because even he didn't know what the phone would reveal.

And somewhere inside that damaged device...

could be the one piece of the past that neither of them was prepared to find.